Martin Luther (1483–1546)

Martin Luther, a Christian priest, rose in revolt in Germany against Rome. After a visit to Rome he became disgusted with the corruption and luxury of the Church. He wrote ninety-five complaints against the Roman Church known as '95 Theses' and nailed it on the door of the church at Wittenberg. He made a few moderate suggestions to reform the church. The role of printing press was a key factor in making his ideas widespread. He argued that Bible alone is supreme and not the Pope and Bishops. He believed that only two main rituals, namely, baptism and Holy Communion are accepted by the Bible. Salvation, he said, could be attained by one's belief in Lord only. In this way the Protestant revolt began. Luther translated the Bible into German and Lutheran Protestants laid down certain rules and regulations. They did not accept the authority of Pope. They had their own churches, administrative set-up and they believed in the supremacy of Bible alone. The rules for priests were relaxed by which they were permitted to lead a married life.



Martin Luther and his 95 Theses

The pope tried to hold peace talks with Luther by calling him for Diet of Worms. It failed. The Diet of Worms disavowed his books and burnt them. He was outlawed from the Holy Roman Empire by the emperor. Martin Luther's radical views influenced many and one such was Thomas Muntzer who fought for a classless society. This started the Peasant's Rebellion in parts of Germany. However, Luther supported the feudal lords in this fight and denounced the peasant movement. As the Protestants became popular there was a civil war in Germany. In the end the northern Germany became Protestant, while the southern state remained catholic.

Zwingli (1484–1531)

Huldrych Zwingli started a similar movement in Switzerland. He was influenced by the Dutch humanist Erasmus. He did not agree with some of Luther's viewpoints. Zwingli believed that Christ lives in the heart of the believer and not in the bread and wine. He had written sixty-seven articles outlining the reformist views against the Catholic Church. Zwingli opposed the celibacy of the monks and construction of monasteries, indulgence, fasting and pilgrimage. Efforts made to bring Luther and Zwingli together for a stronger Protestant movement failed.



Zwingli

Holy Communion (also known as the Eucharist) is a religious ceremony performed in church by Catholics. Catholic Christians partake of Holy Communion in remembrance of the sacrifices made by Jesus. They accept bread and wine which are believed to symbolise (transubstantiation) the body and blood of Jesus Christ.

John Calvin (1509–1564)

Calvin was one of the later leaders of the Protestant movement. As a French Protestant he opposed the activities of the Church. He was excommunicated for fighting the Pope. After his excommunication, he settled In Geneva, Switzerland. His book titled '*Institutes of the Christian Religion*' in Latin contains his core ideas. Calvin was a great organiser and for a while he controlled the



John Calvin

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